

Tejaswin's bronze was similarly significant. His 8,057 points at the Federation Cup earlier in the year had set a higher benchmark, but his Commonwealth Games performance needs to be viewed in the context of the knee problem he had been dealing with. He picked up the ailment just a couple of days before the competition and had already been forced out of the high jump by it. That he was able to complete one of athletics' most demanding events and finish on the podium, not far off Olympic champion Damian Warner and Olympic bronze medallist Lindon Victor, was a considerable achievement.

There were encouraging performances beyond the historic medals. Murali Sreeshankar's silver came with yet another jump beyond eight metres, extending a remarkable run in which he has not jumped below eight metres at any competition this year. His second successive Commonwealth Games silver, after Birmingham, provides another positive sign ahead of the Asian Games.

Neeraj Chopra also left Glasgow with silver. His 85.83m throw was a season's best, coming after he began his campaign late following a recovery from injuries. The mark did not produce the gold medal Indian audiences have come to expect from him, but crossing 85 metres was nevertheless evidence that his recovery is moving in the right direction.

Perhaps the most spectacular surprise came from Yash Vir Singh. His personal-best throw of 85.41m earned him a place on the javelin podium ahead of two Olympic champions, Keshorn Walcott and Arshad Nadeem, as well as two-time world champion Anderson Peters. It was another indication that Indian athletics can produce results beyond its established names.

But the Glasgow campaign was not without its shortcomings. The medal haul could have been greater had some athletes reproduced the standards they had established earlier in the season.

The clearest example came in the



triple jump. Praveen Chithravel and Selva Prabhu finished with silver and bronze respectively, but both were well below their season's bests. Chithravel had jumped 17.09m at the Federation Cup and Selva Prabhu 17.05m at the NCAA competition. In Glasgow, their best efforts were 16.58m and 16.52m respectively. Jamaica's Jordan Scott won gold with 16.72m, a distance that both Indians had already surpassed several times during the season.

There were other disappointments. Gurindervir Singh, who had run a national-record 10.09 earlier in the season, managed only 10.39 in Glasgow. The men's 400m and the mixed 4x400m relay also failed to live up to expectations.

The biggest weakness, however, was the performance of the women's contingent. Only two Indian women, Ravina in the 10,000m race walk and Seema Kaliramna (**pic, above**) in the discus, had met the Athletics Federation of India's automatic qualification standard for the Games.

Of those two, only Seema won a medal.

The absence of gold medals also illustrates the distance still to be covered. Many performances were good enough for the podium without being good enough to defeat the very best in the field. At the World Championships and Olympics, the standard will be significantly higher.

The timing of the Glasgow performance, however, is encouraging. With the Asian Games in Nagoya little more than a month away, there is little time for India's athletes to rest before the next major challenge.

Gulveer Singh will enter the continental competition as a favourite in both his events, while Sreeshankar, Neeraj, Kushare and Tejaswin have all provided evidence that they can compete at a high level. Some of the Indians who did not medal in Glasgow, such as Parul Chaudhary, will also have better prospects at the Asiad.